ENTERTAINMENT

LANDING A PLUM PART

***Ishaan Khatter** makes his US debut in the Netflix thriller series* The Perfect Couple

How many Indian actors can boast about being on a WhatsApp group with Oscar-winner Nicole Kidman and accomplished actors like Liev Schreiber and Isabelle Adjani? Or even dancing with them on a beach? Only one can, and that's Ishaan Khatter. In what's his first Hollywood project, the 28-year-old plays Shooter Dival, the groom's best man whose 'hot bod' happens to catch the bride's eye in the Netflix series *The Perfect Couple*.

Based on the best-selling novel by Elin Hilderbrand, it features a wedding cancelled after the bridesmaid is found dead, resulting in a whodunit where all the groom's family members become suspects. The show has been in the Netflix top 10 across 91 countries since its release on September 5. Unsurprisingly then, Ishaan's Instagram following has soared. "I'm like 'Beware, this is the moment you don't lose yourself'," he says. "I don't want to be a one-hit wonder or the flavour of the season. I am here to stay."

With only a handful of films under his sleeve, an opportunity to act alongside the likes of Kidman this early on would be overwhelming for many, but Khatter didn't let the occasion faze him. "I respect my work above everything," he says.

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The opportunity presented itself after an international talent agent was impressed with his feature debut, Iranian filmmaker Majid Majidi's India-set drama *Beyond the Clouds*. *The Perfect Couple* was only the second part he had to audition for, an exercise he says he has no qualms doing. "I enjoy it because I was able to play with it and learn something," he says. Along with his director Susanne Bier, it was decided that to play Shooter he'd deploy an American accent.

Khatter may not have as much screen time as others, but he'd still pick the part of Shooter, for it "didn't feel like a token South Asian representation character". In a show where all characters have secrets to hide and issues, Shooter comes across as the nicest of the lot. "All of these characters are so ridiculous and at the same time enjoyable and dynamic. Some of them were getting a free range to improvise and be ass***** so it was almost tricky to play someone grounded and real," he says. "I do enjoy the quiet moments and gestures that are definitive of who he is. There is a mystery to him which makes him sexy and intriguing."

Khatter's next will also be a Netflix series albeit an Indian affair and a rom-com titled *The Royals* alongside Bhumi Pednekar and also featuring Zeenat Aman. For now, though, he is riding high on the female attention that's coming his way, courtesy *The Perfect Couple*. "A moment like this will allow people to see me in a different way and maybe it will end up in an opportunity," he says. The question is if it will be in India or abroad. Khatter knows his mind well. "Wherever the good work is, is where I will go," he says. ■

–Suhani Singh

